

Meridian Coffee Roasters — Operations Handbook 2026

1. Company Overview

Meridian Coffee Roasters was founded in March 2016 in Leeds, United Kingdom, by Ada Okonkwo and Tomas Rehak. The company roasts speciality arabica coffee for wholesale and retail customers across the United Kingdom and Ireland. As of 1 January 2026 the company employs 187 people, of whom 94 work at the Leeds roastery, 61 across the eleven retail cafes, and 32 in central functions including finance, marketing and logistics. The company operates a single roasting facility on Kirkstall Road in Leeds, fitted with three Loring S35 Kestrel roasters. Combined annual roasting capacity is 940 tonnes of green coffee. In the 2025 financial year the facility processed 611 tonnes, representing 65 percent utilisation. Meridian holds B Corporation certification, first awarded in November 2021 and recertified in November 2024 with a score of 96.4 points. The company is a private limited company registered in England and Wales under company number 10244871.

2. Sourcing and Green Coffee

Meridian buys green coffee from fourteen supplier relationships across seven countries: Ethiopia, Colombia, Guatemala, Rwanda, Brazil, Peru and Indonesia. Roughly 71 percent of volume is bought through direct trade agreements with individual producers or cooperatives, and the remainder through two specialist importers, Falcon Coffees and Nordic Approach. The minimum price paid to producers under the direct trade programme is 2.80 US dollars per pound, which is well above the Fairtrade floor price. In the 2025 buying season the average price paid was 3.94 US dollars per pound. The single largest supplier by volume is the Kayon Mountain Farm in the Guji zone of Ethiopia, which supplied 84 tonnes in 2025. Green coffee is stored in a temperature controlled warehouse adjacent to the roastery, held between 18 and 22 degrees Celsius at a relative humidity of 55 to 60 percent. Maximum recommended storage time for green coffee is nine months from the date of arrival. Stock is rotated on a first in, first out basis, and every lot is cupped on arrival and again at three month intervals. Quality control rejects any lot scoring below 84 points on the Specialty Coffee Association scale. In 2025 three lots were rejected, totalling 11 tonnes, all due to phenolic defects traced to a single wet mill in Peru. That supplier relationship was discontinued in August 2025.

3. Roasting Operations

The roastery runs two shifts, Monday to Friday. The early shift runs from 05:30 to 13:30 and the late shift from 13:30 to 21:30. Saturday roasting is scheduled only during the November and December peak, and requires approval from the Head of Production. Each roaster is calibrated weekly against a reference profile. Calibration involves roasting a two kilogram sample of the Brazil Cerrado benchmark lot and comparing the resulting Agtron score against a target of 58 plus or minus 2 points. Any roaster reading outside that tolerance is taken offline until a technician has inspected the bean probe and the airflow damper. The standard roast profile for the house espresso blend, Northbound, reaches first crack at 8 minutes and 40 seconds and completes at 11 minutes and 15 seconds, with a charge temperature of 196 degrees Celsius. Development time ratio is held between 22 and 24 percent. Roasted coffee is rested for a minimum of 48 hours before dispatch, and 72 hours for espresso roasts. Packaged coffee carries a best before date of twelve months from the roast date, though the recommended consumption window printed on retail bags is six weeks from roasting. Batch records are retained for seven years. Every batch record captures the green lot number, the roaster identifier, the operator, the full time and temperature curve, the end weight, and the

calculated weight loss percentage. Typical weight loss for a medium roast is between 14.5 and 16 percent.

4. Health, Safety and Maintenance

Hearing protection is mandatory in the roastery whenever the destoner or the grinder is operating, as measured noise levels reach 87 decibels. The company provides moulded earplugs to all production staff, replaced annually. The chaff collector must be emptied at the end of every shift without exception. Accumulated chaff is the single largest fire risk in the facility. In the event of a roaster drum fire, operators must not open the drum door. The correct procedure is to cut the gas at the wall isolator, engage the drum cooling water spray, and allow the drum to rotate until the temperature falls below 60 degrees Celsius. The fire service should be called if the temperature has not fallen within ten minutes. The gas supply is inspected annually by a Gas Safe registered engineer. The last inspection was completed on 14 October 2025 and the next is due by 14 October 2026. Fire extinguishers are serviced every six months. The roastery holds two carbon dioxide extinguishers and four foam extinguishers, positioned at the roaster line, the packing bench, the warehouse door and the staff corridor. Deep cleaning of the roaster cyclones is scheduled every 250 operating hours. The afterburner is serviced every 1,000 operating hours by the manufacturer's approved technician.

5. Wholesale and Retail

Meridian supplies 340 wholesale accounts. The largest single account is the Northern Rail catering contract, which accounts for 9 percent of wholesale revenue. Standard wholesale payment terms are 30 days from invoice date. Accounts more than 60 days overdue are placed on credit hold automatically. Wholesale customers receive free delivery on orders above 40 kilograms within the Leeds, Manchester, Sheffield and York delivery zones. Orders below that threshold carry a delivery charge of 7 pounds 50 pence. Deliveries run Tuesday and Thursday in Leeds and Wednesday elsewhere. The eleven retail cafes trade under the Meridian name. The flagship site on Briggate in Leeds opened in September 2018 and remains the highest turnover location, taking 1.34 million pounds in the 2025 financial year. The newest site, in Chester, opened in June 2025. Revenue for the financial year ending 31 December 2025 was 21.7 million pounds, an increase of 12.4 percent on the prior year. Wholesale contributed 13.1 million pounds, retail 7.9 million pounds and online sales 0.7 million pounds. Gross margin was 38.2 percent. Earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortisation were 2.41 million pounds.

6. Environmental Commitments

Meridian committed in 2023 to reaching net zero across scope 1 and scope 2 emissions by 2030. Scope 1 and 2 emissions for 2025 totalled 412 tonnes of carbon dioxide equivalent, down from 486 tonnes in 2024. The roastery has been powered by a certified renewable electricity tariff since April 2022. All retail packaging has been home compostable since January 2024. The company estimates this removes approximately 1.9 tonnes of plastic from circulation each year. Spent coffee grounds from the eleven cafes are collected weekly by a local anaerobic digestion partner, diverting around 46 tonnes of organic waste from landfill annually. The company does not currently measure scope 3 emissions in full, though a first assessment covering green coffee transport was completed in 2025 and estimated 1,940 tonnes of carbon dioxide equivalent. A complete scope 3 inventory is planned for the 2027 financial year.